



***Polypocephalus visakhapatnamensis* sp. nov.** (Lecanicephalidea: Polypocephalidae) from *Himantura uarnak* (Forsskål) and *Dasyatis (Amphotistius) zugei* (Müller & Henle) from Visakhapatnam coast

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ABSTRACT. *Polypocephalus visakhapatnamensis* sp. nov. has been described from the spiral valves of *Himantura uarnak* (Forsskål) and *Dasyatis (Amphotistius) zugei* (Müller & Henle) at Visakhapatnam coast, Bay of Bengal, India. It has been compared with other valid species of the genus *Polypocephalus* Braun, 1878, and has been characterized in having large body size, acraspedote proglottids, eight bifurcated tentacles, presence of neck, four testes, transversely elongated vitelline mass below the ovary and cirrus in the middle of proglottid.

Keywords: acraspedote proglottids, biological indicators, *Dasyatis (Amphotistius) zugei*, *Himantura uarnak*, *Polypocephalus*, spiral valves

A diversified array of elasmobranchs occurs in Bay of Bengal, India. They constitute an important group of fishes by the virtue of their abundant occurrence, cosmopolitan distribution and commercial value. Among them, rays are excellent commercial food fish in East coast of India due to their high protein content. Rays serve as an imperative host as they carry a range of host-specific parasites, which can be used as 'biological indicators'. Studies of their parasitic fauna, in particular cestodes, are limited and it might, therefore, be expected that studies on cestodes of rays in this region will reveal diverse and novel taxa. Rays offer an excellent habitat to diversified array of cestode parasitic fauna, in particular tetrathyrids, lecanicephalids and trypanorhynchids. Lecanicephalids predominate the cestode parasitic fauna in these host fishes.

In the present study, a new species *Polypocephalus visakhapatnamensis* sp. nov. has been described from the spiral valves of *Himantura uarnak* (Forsskål) and *Dasyatis (Amphotistius) zugei* (Müller & Henle). Genus identification was done with the aid of standard books by Yamaguti (1959), Schmidt (1986), Khalil *et al.* (1994) and other literature pertaining to the genus *Polypocephalus*.

A survey has been conducted to study cestode parasitic fauna from the Elasmobranchs at Visakhapatnam coast, Bay of Bengal, and about 225 *H. uarnak* (Forsskål) and 158 *D. (A.) zugei* (Müller & Henle) were examined thoroughly for the cestode parasites. Cestode parasites usually parasitize the spiral valves of the intestine. Spiral valves of the host fish were separated, washed in physiological saline to remove excess mucus and were cut open with a longitudinal incision. Parasites were carefully alienated from the spiral valves and collected in cavity blocks filled with saline solution.

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